got nipped in the bud. It also marked the beginning of the end of the National Democratic Front of Bodoland (NDFB) and hugely impacted the standing of the United Liberation Front of Assam (Independent) ULFA (I), which significantly enabled the return of peace in Assam. This operation stands out as a maiden joint operation with the MA after Operation Golden Bird undertaken in 1995 (which incidentally got aborted by the MA due to controversies surrounding the presenting of the Nehru Award for goodwill and friendship to Aung San Suu Kyi). As is the norm, it was preceded by diligent joint planning through some crucial staff visits and interactions between the two sides. To enable the smooth conduct of this operation, the coordination of command, control and communication was immaculately worked out. In fact, we also exchanged Liaison Officers (LOs) who enabled intricate ground coordination.

Talking about LOs, I am reminded of an incident. Late one night while the operation was at its peak, I got a frantic call from my BGS seeking permission to pull back some of our columns placed astride the IMB by at least 2 km. Perplexed by this novel idea, I queried the reason and was promptly told that it was a request from the MA, through our LO. They were about to engage an insurgent camp in close proximity to our troops with artillery or mortar ammunition of Chinese make. They had a bad experience with its accuracy; they were not quite sure where the rounds would land, hence this request as a precautionary measure to avoid any collateral damage. On a serious note, in hindsight, I must acknowledge the unprecedented cooperation and coordination from the MA during this operation. Unlike Operation Golden Bird,[6] Operation Sunrise was much larger in time, space and force matrix on both sides. It witnessed exemplary cooperation between the two armies.

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